Q+A

OUR DAILY BREAD

VIKAS KHANNA'S 'Feed India' campaign has brought relief to millions during the pandemic. In his new book *Barkat*, the Michelin-starred chef explains what drives him



Q. You are no stranger to writing—*Barkat* being your 37th book. Do you enjoy the process of putting pen to paper?

It is an absolutely amazing way to share our journeys and inspiration, and to document what is happening in the world or what you are going through at a given period. It helps me represent my culture and cuisine and my emotions.

Q. This book pays tribute to your roots, particularly Amritsar. How important has your upbringing been in taking you to where you are now?

Barkat, from its very conception, was supposed to be a semi-autobiography. The values of growing up in a joint family are unlike any education a child can get. I believe that the inheritance of culture comes from your grandparents. Growing up in Amritsar, one of the most important tenets I learned was *seva*. All those values helped me bring together Feed India.

Q. How have your faith, religion and community inspired your culinary journey?

I am not someone who prays every day, but I am extremely ritualistic. Religion inspires me, sometimes keeps me safe. On days when you are out of everything—luck, money, friends, family—it is faith that holds you together.

Q. You named the Feed India initiative after your grandmother's favourite word 'Barkat' (abundance). How much did your family impact this initiative?

My mother inspired me. In the second week of April 2020, I called my mum and told her I won't be able to carry on with this initiative. She told me that she wanted her son to support the country, to stand up and feed India. It's how the initiative got the name. Family is important because they can help you understand your roots and reboot your moral compass.

—with Joanna Lobo

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